

SOLEA AV

Audio & Visual Solutions for Sacred Spaces

Business Plan

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Prepared for Internal Use

CONFIDENTIAL

1. Executive Summary

Solea AV is a bootstrapped, service-based company providing audio-visual installation, consulting, and system design for Orthodox, Catholic, and other high-liturgical churches across the Northeastern United States. The company is founded by a degreed audio engineer with hands-on installation experience in liturgical settings and deep roots in the Orthodox Christian community.

The company operates lean: no debt, no warehouse, no employees. Revenue comes from labor on installations and markup on equipment, with a clear path to full-time operation once the business sustains six-figure owner income.

Year 1 Target: \$36,000 net profit (\$3,000/month) while maintaining full-time employment.

Long-Term Vision: Full-time operation with 2-3 team members serving liturgical communities across the Northeast, generating six-figure owner income.

2. The Problem We Solve

High-liturgical churches face a unique set of AV challenges that general contractors consistently fail to address:

- Ugly, visible microphones at the kliros (choir stand) and altar that disrupt the visual reverence of the space
- Poor vocal clarity for clergy, chanters, and readers due to improperly tuned systems
- Insufficient wireless microphone packs, forcing deacons to physically hand off mics during services
- No audio coverage in the narthex, cry rooms, or parish halls where families with young children gather
- No livestreaming capability despite growing demand from elderly, homebound, and distant parishioners
- Overly complicated systems that volunteers cannot operate or troubleshoot
- General AV contractors who do not understand liturgical flow, acoustic needs of chant, or the theological importance of the worship space

These are not minor inconveniences. They directly affect the worship experience, accessibility, and outreach capacity of every parish that suffers from them. Most churches know they have a problem but do not know who to call, and the contractors they do find treat them like a conference room install.

3. Our Competitive Advantage

Solea AV has four distinct advantages that a generic AV contractor cannot replicate:

Liturgical Insider Knowledge: The founder is an Orthodox Christian and a Reader at his parish. He understands the flow of the Divine Liturgy, Vespers, Matins, and feast-day services. He knows when the deacon moves, when the choir responds, when silence matters. This is not something you can learn from a product catalog.

Professional Audio Engineering: The founder holds a degree in audio engineering and has extensive professional experience in audio supervision at a major performing arts institution. This is not a hobbyist operation.

Proven Track Record: Solea AV has already completed installations at Holy Resurrection Bulgarian Orthodox Church (Boston) and St. Dumitru Romanian Monastery (Middletown, NY), including parish school facilities. These are referenceable projects.

Trust and Blessing: The founder has the blessing of clergy to pursue this work. In Orthodox communities, this carries real weight. Clergy referrals are the single most powerful sales channel in this market.

4. Target Market

Primary Market (Year 1-2)

Orthodox Christian parishes in the Northeastern United States, with an estimated 160-200 parishes within a 3-hour drive of Boston. This is a substantial addressable market. It includes Greek Orthodox (GOA), Antiochian, OCA, ROCOR, Bulgarian, Romanian, Serbian, and other jurisdictions. Each jurisdiction has its own decision-making culture: some are priest-driven, some require parish council approval, and some need diocesan sign-off. The founder will need to learn these differences as you encounter them, but the existing Orthodox identity of the founder gives Solea AV a foundation of trust across all of them. Even a 5% conversion rate in Year 1 would yield 8-10 projects from the Orthodox market alone, before any Catholic or Episcopal outreach.

Secondary Market (Year 2+)

Catholic parishes (Roman Catholic and Eastern Catholic), Episcopal/Anglican churches, and other high-liturgical traditions. These will likely require cold outreach and a portfolio to break into, but the installed base is enormous and the needs are very similar.

Tertiary Services

Parish school classrooms, fellowship halls, and multi-purpose spaces within church facilities. The founder has already done this type of work for his own parish school library.

5. Service Offerings

Core services, ordered by current readiness and market demand:

Service	Description	Readiness	Priority
Sound Reinforcement	Clergy mics, choir coverage, narthex/cry room speakers, system tuning	Ready Now	Highest
Wireless Systems	Proper wireless mic packs so deacons/clergy stop handing off mics	Ready Now	Highest
Livestreaming	Camera, encoder, streaming setup for YouTube/Facebook	Needs Training	High

Consulting / System Design	Spec systems for churches hiring general contractors	Ready Now	High
Classroom / Hall AV	Projectors, screens, basic audio for parish schools and halls	Needs Training	Medium
Hearing Loops	Induction loop systems for hearing-impaired parishioners	Needs Training	Medium
Maintenance Contracts	Ongoing support, tuning, and troubleshooting agreements	Ready Now	Later Phase

6. Pricing Strategy

Why You Must Charge More Than You Think

Based on comparable completed projects, early estimates were \$1,000 labor for a 6-hour two-person install and \$500-750 for a 3-hour solo swap. Let us examine why these numbers are too low.

The labor rate at those prices works out to roughly \$83-125/hour before expenses. That sounds high until accounting for reality: site survey time (unpaid), drive time, vehicle wear, insurance, tools, quoting and communication time, LLC costs, and taxes (self-employment tax alone is 15.3%). After all of that, the effective rate at those prices is closer to \$40-60/hour. That is less than what a general handyman charges in the Boston area.

Solea AV is not a handyman operation. The founder is a degreed audio engineer with institutional experience, liturgical expertise, and specialized knowledge. Pricing should reflect that.

Recommended Pricing Structure

Component	Rate	Notes
Site Survey / Consultation	\$150-250 flat fee	Credit toward project if hired. Weeds out non-serious inquiries.
Labor (Installation)	\$125-175/hour	Reflects specialized liturgical AV expertise. Track all hours including prep.
Equipment Markup	20-35% over your cost	Standard in AV industry. Higher for complex sourcing, lower for simple commodity gear.
System Design / Consulting Only	\$500-1,500 per project	For churches that hire their own contractors but need a proper spec.
Helper / Assistant Day Rate	Bill at \$75-100/hour	Pay your helper \$25-40/hour. You keep the margin for coordination.

7. Year 1 Financial Projections

These projections assume Solea AV completes one project per month on average, with project sizes growing as reputation builds. This is conservative.

Project Type	Qty/Year	Avg Revenue	Avg Profit	Annual Profit
Small Install	4	\$3,500	\$1,200	\$4,800
Medium Install	4	\$6,000	\$2,200	\$8,800
Large Install	2	\$12,000	\$4,000	\$8,000
Consulting Only	3	\$800	\$750	\$2,250
Site Surveys (not hired)	4	\$200	\$200	\$800
TOTAL YEAR 1	17 engagements			\$24,650

Estimated Year 1 Expenses

Expense	Estimated Annual Cost
General Liability Insurance	\$500-800
DBA Registration (Massachusetts)	\$50-100
Website (domain, hosting, basic build)	\$200-500
Business Cards & Marketing Materials	\$100-200
Gas & Vehicle Costs	\$1,200-1,800
Miscellaneous Tools & Supplies	\$300-500
Accounting / Tax Software	\$200-300
TOTAL ESTIMATED EXPENSES	\$2,550-4,200

With \$24,650 in gross profit and roughly \$3,000-4,000 in overhead, the net profit projection for Year 1 is approximately \$20,000-21,000. That is roughly \$1,700/month. To hit the \$3,000/month target, Solea AV would need approximately 14-15 projects instead of 10, or a shift toward more medium and large installs. This is ambitious but achievable if the marketing and referral pipeline works as planned.

Important: these projections do not include self-employment tax (15.3% on net earnings). Set aside at least 25-30% of net profit for federal and state taxes. Open a separate savings account for this.

8. Legal, Insurance & Administrative Setup

Immediate Actions Required

DBA Filing: File a DBA ("Doing Business As") for "Solea AV" under the existing LLC. In Massachusetts, this is called a "Fictitious Name" filing and is done with the city or town clerk where you operate. Typical cost is \$25-65.

General Liability Insurance: This is non-negotiable before the first paid job. The company needs a policy that covers property damage (drilling into a wall and hitting a pipe, dropping equipment on a marble floor) and bodily injury. Look for a policy with at least \$1 million per occurrence. Companies like Next Insurance, Hiscox, or Thimble offer policies for contractors starting around \$40-60/month. Some churches will require a Certificate of Insurance (COI) before allowing you on-site.

Low-Voltage Licensing: This is something I am not certain about and you need to research. Massachusetts may require a low-voltage technician license for certain types of AV installation work. Check with the Massachusetts Division of Professional Licensure. Some states you work in (New York, Connecticut) may have different requirements. Do not skip this step.

Business Bank Account: Open a separate business checking account under the LLC (DBA Solea AV). Keep every business transaction separate from personal finances. This is critical for tax purposes and for looking professional when invoicing churches.

Accounting: Use QuickBooks Self-Employed or Wave (free) to track every expense, every invoice, every mile driven. Save every receipt. You will thank yourself at tax time.

Contract Template: Create a standard project agreement that covers scope of work, payment terms, timeline, warranty, and liability. We can build this separately. Do not start work without a signed agreement.

9. Equipment Strategy

Dealer Programs

Becoming an authorized dealer for professional AV brands is one of the most important business decisions the company will make. Here is why: dealer pricing typically gives 30-50% off retail. Even marking up equipment 20-35% to the client, the actual margin on equipment is significant. On a \$5,000 equipment order, the difference between buying at retail vs. dealer cost could be \$1,500 or more in margin.

Brands to investigate for dealer programs:

- QSC (amplifiers, processors, speakers) - widely used in install, excellent dealer program
- Shure (wireless microphones, wired mics) - a product line the founder knows well
- Biamp (DSPs, Tesira platform) - strong in commercial install
- Yamaha (mixers, speakers, amplifiers) - broad product line, familiar to you
- Sennheiser (wireless systems) - alternative to Shure for wireless
- Crestron or Extron (control systems, video distribution) - for future video service expansion
- Epson or BenQ (projectors) - for classroom and parish hall installs

Start by applying to QSC and Shure dealer programs. Most require proof of business (the LLC), liability insurance, and sometimes a minimum annual purchase volume. Some have tiered programs where you can start small.

In the meantime, the company can purchase equipment through distributors like Sweetwater Commercial, B&H, or Full Compass. Pricing will not be as good as dealer direct, but it works for getting started.

0% Financing

Solea AV has access to 0% APR equipment financing for up to 2 years through established vendor relationships. This means the company can take on a project, purchase the required equipment with monthly installments, collect payment from the church, and begin repaying the financing, all without carrying high-interest debt. The key discipline is to never purchase equipment speculatively. Only buy what has a signed contract behind it.

10. Marketing & Client Acquisition

Channel 1: Clergy Referrals (Highest Priority)

This is the number one channel and it costs nothing. Orthodox parishes are tight-knit. A recommendation from one priest to another carries more weight than any website or advertisement. The plan should be:

1. Ask the parish priest at Holy Resurrection to introduce Solea AV to other clergy in the area or mention the company's services at clergy gatherings
2. Ask the abbot or priest at St. Dumitru Monastery to do the same within their network
3. Prepare a simple one-page leave-behind (printed, not just digital) that a priest can hand to another priest or parish council member
4. Offer to do a free 30-minute walkthrough and assessment for any parish a priest refers the company to (this is not free work, it is lead generation disguised as generosity, and it is authentic to how Orthodox communities operate)

Channel 2: Website & SEO

A professional website is important for credibility. When a parish council searches online after hearing about Solea AV from their priest, they need to find a real business. The website should include:

- Clear explanation of what Solea AV does and who it serves
- Photos and brief case studies from Holy Resurrection and St. Dumitru (with permission)
- A page specifically addressing Orthodox church audio challenges (this becomes the SEO anchor)
- A page for Catholic and Episcopal churches
- A simple contact form
- Your credentials and a professional photo

For SEO: the phrases to rank for include "Orthodox church audio installation," "church sound system installer Northeast," "liturgical AV solutions," and similar. There is almost certainly very little competition for these terms, which means even a modest website with good content can

rank on the first page. Consider writing 2-3 blog posts about common church audio problems as content marketing.

Channel 3: Diocesan and Pan-Orthodox Events

Research upcoming clergy-laity congresses, diocesan assemblies, and pan-Orthodox gatherings in the Northeast. These are goldmine networking events. Even attending as a parishioner and having conversations is valuable. If any event has a vendor or exhibitor option, consider it in Year 2 when Solea AV has more projects completed.

Channel 4: Social Media

A modest presence on Facebook and Instagram showing your work is sufficient. Do not invest heavily here. The target clients are not scrolling Instagram for AV contractors. They are talking to their priest. That said, many Orthodox parish communities have active Facebook groups, and being visible there as someone who does this work has value.

11. Skills Development Plan

The founder is strong on audio. Identified gaps are in video, networking, and livestreaming. Here is a prioritized training plan using free or low-cost resources:

Immediate (Next 30 Days)

5. Complete Dante Level 1, 2, and 3 Certification (free, online at audinate.com) - this is directly billable expertise
6. Shure webinars on wireless microphone best practices and frequency coordination (free at shure.com/webinars)
7. QSC online training modules for Q-SYS platform (free at qsc.com/training)

Within 90 Days

8. YouTube channels: Worship Sound Guy, Behind the Mixer, and Production Nerds cover church-specific audio and video extensively
9. Basic livestreaming: learn OBS Studio (free), camera basics for streaming, and encoder setup. Practice at the home parish first.
10. Networking fundamentals: Dante accreditation will cover much of this. Supplement with free resources on VLANs and managed switches from Netgear or Cisco YouTube channels.

Within 6 Months

11. Hearing loop system design - contact Contacta or Williams AV for free training resources on induction loop design
12. Crestron or Extron online training when pursuing video distribution and control system projects
13. AVIXA CTS certification (paid, approximately \$300-400 for the exam) - consider this when revenue justifies it, as it adds significant credibility for larger projects

12. Site Survey Process

You need a repeatable process for evaluating a church before you quote a project. Here is a framework:

Pre-Visit

14. Phone or video call with the priest or parish council contact to understand their concerns and budget expectations
15. Ask for photos of the current setup, the nave, narthex, and any problem areas
16. Confirm decision-making authority: is this the priest's call, parish council vote, or does it need diocesan approval?

On-Site

17. Walk the entire space: nave, narthex, cry room, parish hall, classrooms, exterior
18. Document existing equipment (make, model, condition, age)
19. Take measurements and photos of speaker locations, mic positions, cable runs, electrical access
20. Listen to the acoustics: clap test, note reverb time, identify problem frequencies
21. If an RTA mic is available, take basic measurements
22. Note the liturgical flow: where does the priest stand, where does the deacon move, where is the kliros, where do readers stand
23. Identify cable pathways, attic access, conduit, and any historic preservation concerns

Post-Visit

24. Write a findings summary with photos
25. Develop a system design with equipment list and costs
26. Prepare a formal proposal with scope, timeline, and pricing
27. Present to priest/council in person or on a call

13. Phased Action Plan

Phase 1: Foundation (Now - 30 Days)

Set up the business infrastructure. Zero revenue expected.

- ☐ File DBA for "Solea AV" with the town clerk
- ☐ Open a business bank account
- ☐ Get general liability insurance quotes (Next, Hiscox, Thimble) and bind a policy
- ☐ Research Massachusetts low-voltage licensing requirements
- ☐ Create a one-page service overview / leave-behind document
- ☐ Begin Dante certification (Levels 1-3)
- ☐ Take professional photos of your completed installations at Holy Resurrection and St. Dumitru
- ☐ Draft a standard project contract template
- ☐ Set up QuickBooks or Wave accounting
- ☐ Contact the first potential client church and schedule a site survey

Phase 2: First Paying Project (Days 30-90)

Goal: close and complete your first paid installation. Prove the model works.

- ☐ Conduct your first paid site survey
- ☐ Deliver a professional proposal to the first potential client
- ☐ Close and execute your first project
- ☐ Document everything with before/after photos and notes
- ☐ Ask the priest for a testimonial and permission to use as a case study
- ☐ Begin building the website
- ☐ Ask the parish priest to mention Solea AV's services to other clergy
- ☐ Apply for QSC and Shure dealer programs

Phase 3: Build Pipeline (Months 3-6)

Goal: 2-3 completed projects and a pipeline of future work. Revenue should be flowing.

- ☐ Launch website with case studies and SEO content
- ☐ Complete 2-3 additional projects
- ☐ Begin livestreaming training (practice at the home parish)
- ☐ Attend any Orthodox clergy gatherings or diocesan events in the area
- ☐ Develop relationships with 3-5 priests who can refer you
- ☐ Refine pricing based on actual project data
- ☐ Set up basic social media presence (Facebook page, Instagram)

Phase 4: Growth (Months 6-12)

Goal: consistent monthly revenue, expanding service offerings, and a reputation in the Orthodox community.

- ☐ Complete 6-10 total projects in Year 1
- ☐ Add livestreaming as a service offering once training is complete
- ☐ Begin cold outreach to Catholic parishes if Orthodox pipeline is strong
- ☐ Consider AVIXA CTS certification
- ☐ Evaluate whether maintenance contracts make sense to offer
- ☐ Bring on additional help for larger jobs as needed
- ☐ Review Year 1 financials and plan Year 2

14. Risks & Honest Unknowns

A good business plan acknowledges what could go wrong. Here are the risks I see and what I am uncertain about:

- Low-voltage licensing: Massachusetts requirements. requirements are unclear. If a license is required and takes months to obtain, it could delay your first paid project. Research this immediately.
- Church budget cycles: Many parishes operate on tight annual budgets and may only approve capital expenditures at certain times of year (typically at annual parish assemblies in the fall or winter). Your sales cycle could be longer than expected.
- Scope creep: Churches will ask for "one more thing" constantly. The contract must clearly define scope. Learn to say "I can absolutely do that, and here is what it will cost."
- Volunteer comparison: Some parish council members will compare the pricing to "the guy in the parish who knows about computers." Be prepared to clearly articulate the difference between professional installation and volunteer tinkering.
- Insurance claims: One accidental damage to a historic iconostasis or marble floor could be financially devastating without proper insurance. Do not skip the insurance.
- Competitor pricing: There is no current data on what general AV contractors charge these churches. Before finalizing pricing, try to get a few data points. Ask friendly parish council members if they have gotten quotes from other vendors.
- Video and networking skills: These are acknowledged gaps. Do not take on livestreaming or network-heavy projects until adequate training is complete. Refer those projects out or partner with someone who has the expertise until confidence is established.

15. Business Name & Branding

Name: Solea AV

"Solea" refers to the raised platform in front of the iconostasis in Orthodox churches, the space where clergy and deacons serve. It is a word with deep liturgical meaning that Orthodox Christians will recognize immediately, while remaining subtle and professional enough that Catholic and Episcopal churches will not feel excluded. It is short, memorable, and distinctive in the AV industry.

Branding direction: clean, professional, subtly sacred. Think warm golds, deep blues or burgundy, clean typography. No clip-art crosses, no overly ornate design. Solea AV should look

like a professional AV firm that happens to specialize in sacred spaces, not a church bookstore. The brand should feel trustworthy and competent, which is exactly what a parish council wants to see before approving a \$5,000-15,000 expenditure.

The domain soleaav.com has been secured along with matching social media handles.

16. Your Next 5 Actions

Stop reading and do these five things this week:

1. **Research Massachusetts low-voltage licensing requirements.** Call the Division of Professional Licensure or check their website. This could be a blocker.
2. **Get 3 general liability insurance quotes.** Go to Next Insurance, Hiscox, and Thimble websites. It takes 10 minutes each.
3. **Contact the first potential client church.** Call the priest. Schedule a walkthrough. Do not wait until everything is perfect.
4. **File your DBA.** Go to your town clerk's office or website. It costs \$25-65 and takes 15 minutes.
5. **Start Dante Level 1 certification.** Free at audinate.com. Level 1 can be finished in a single sitting.

Solea AV - Glory to God in all things.